

# TRANSITION TO ADULTHOOD GUIDELINES FOR INDIVIDUALS WITH AUTISM SPECTRUM DISORDERS (ASD)



# Acknowledgments

This publication is the result of recommendations by the Ohio Autism Task Force and the support of the Ohio Center for Autism and Low Incidence (OCALI) Transition to Community Task Force.

Funding for the Transition to Adulthood Guidelines for Individuals with Autism Spectrum Disorders has been made possible through the support of the Ohio Department of Education.

Written and Edited By:

Chris Filler, OCALI  
Madeline Rosenshein

Special thanks to the following individuals for their time, effort and support in the development of these guidelines:

Bob Baer  
Kay Brown  
Pat Cloppert  
Lawrence Dennis  
Reena Fish  
Tom Fish  
Peter Gerhardt  
Earnestine Hargett  
Margo Izzo  
Michael Kinney  
Pat Luchkowsky  
John Magee  
Colleen Miller  
Terri Moore  
Donna Owens  
Leslie Paull  
Representative Jon M. Peterson  
Lauren Phelps  
Michael Schroeder  
Debbie Smith  
Deb Stroud  
Kay Treanor  
Ellen Williams  
Barb Yavorcik

These guidelines may be reproduced and distributed for non-commercial educational purposes.  
Credit must be given to OCALI.

Copyright © 2008 Ohio Center for Autism and Low Incidence  
All Rights Reserved.



## INTRODUCTION

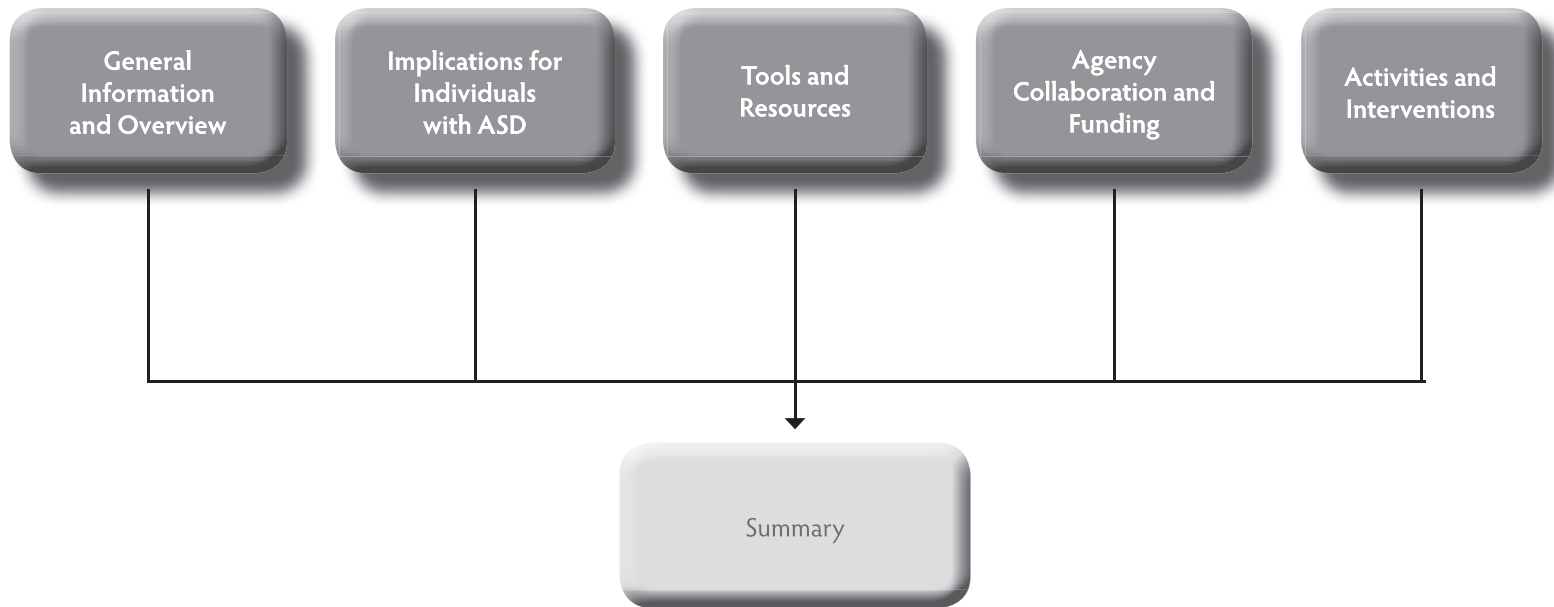
Transition to adulthood and the community beyond high school can present many challenges to individuals with autism spectrum disorder (ASD) and their families. In some cases the student with ASD may leave a protected, familiar and structured environment of the school system and establish new connections and support systems. Even when an individual with ASD obtains a job, finding and funding ongoing supports such as a job coach to maintain employment can be difficult. Sometimes connections with adult service providers are frustrating and difficult to make when eligibility decisions are based on a lack of knowledge about autism and the implications for a specific individual. Does the individual with ASD present too many challenges without the necessary supports to demonstrate her strengths? Or does she appear very verbal and competent in an interview while masking the difficulties they may have with self-care, understanding conversations or following multi-step directions? Adults with ASD are often underemployed or find jobs and lose them repeatedly because of behavioral or communication issues. Every day families struggle with issues related to repetitive behaviors, lack of friends and recreation opportunities and long waiting lists for supported living options.

### ASD Transition Guidelines



Each of the seven sections that make up the *ASD Transition Guidelines* will provide information and resources that address the specific challenges individuals with ASD and their families face throughout the transition process. All sections are important for a successful transition although finding a job is often thought of as a key indicator. Thus, all of us enjoy lives that are enriched not just by work but with friendships, leisure interests and home and family. Each of the seven sections can stand alone, and for this reason they have a similar format. For example, if you are only looking for information on waivers, go to the Supported Living section and get the information you need quickly.

## SECTION OVERVIEW

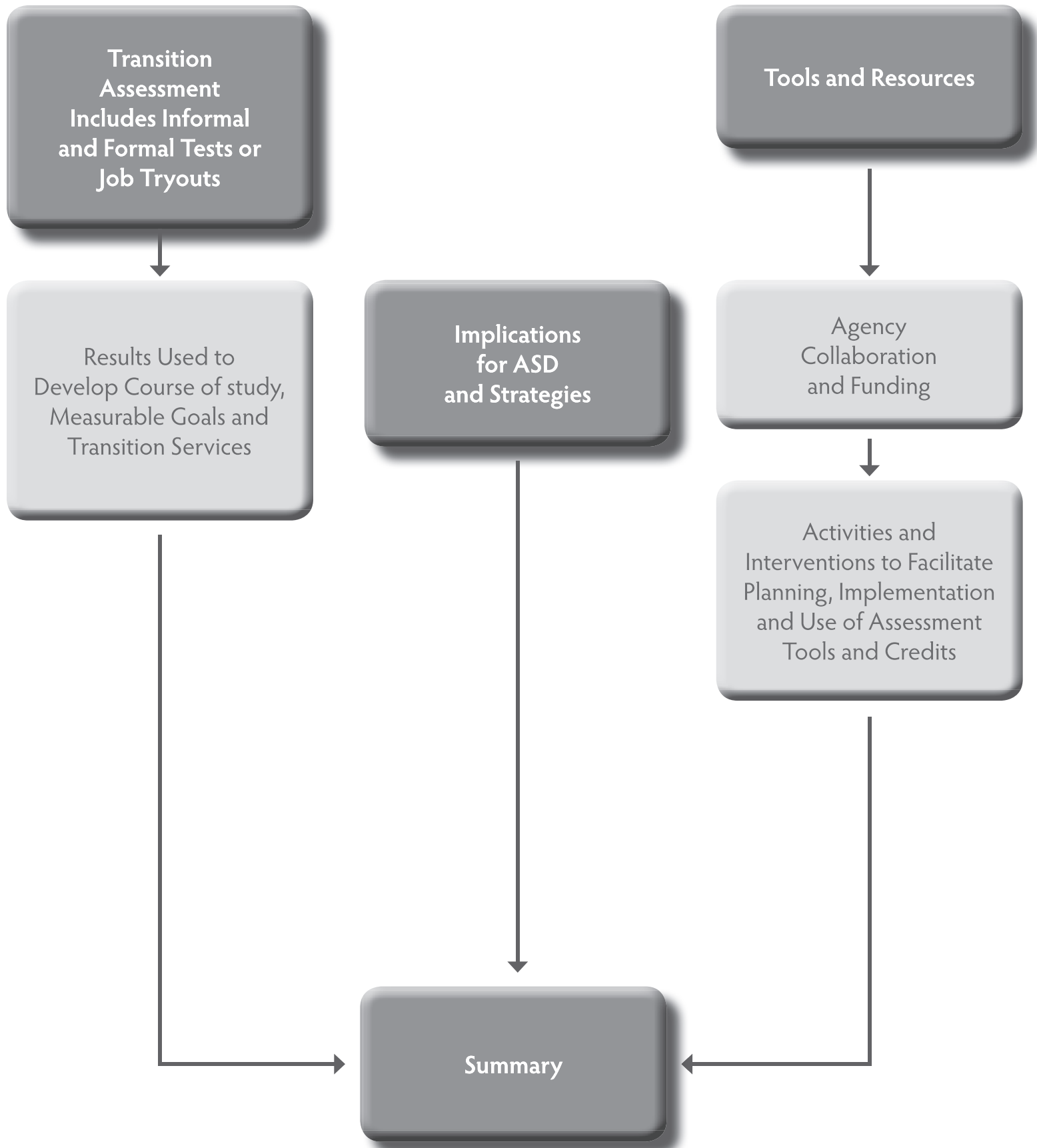


1. *General Information* gives concise background information and description of key issues related to ASD and transition..
2. *Implications for Students or Individuals with ASD* are presented in a table in each section (except legal) that describes characteristics of ASD such as sensory, social, behavior and organization within the context of the subject of a given section, such as age-appropriate transition assessment and a corresponding list of strategies or interventions that might be considered. For example, in the Community Participation section the table may list strategies for a student with ASD who wants to participate in a community game club, such as an orientation where he observes the games being played, has a social skills script or a step-by-step sequence of steps (possibly with pictures) for each game so he can play without anxiety.
3. *Tools and Resources* link to many free online resources that can be downloaded or viewed.
4. *Agency Collaboration and Funding* list agencies that may support or extend transition services with funding or experiences.
5. *Activities or Interventions* list ideas for activities that reinforce, develop or extend the concepts discussed in the section.

The content of each section also reflects the evidence-based transition practices developed by the National Secondary Transition and Technical Assistance Center (NSTTAC) and the key components of transition programming described in Kohler's taxonomy: student-focused planning, student development, family involvement, program structure and interagency collaboration. For more information, go to <http://www.nsttac.org>

# AGE-APPROPRIATE TRANSITION ASSESSMENT

## SECTION 2



## AGE-APPROPRIATE TRANSITION ASSESSMENT

### GUIDING QUESTIONS

- ▶ What is age-appropriate transition assessment?
- ▶ Why is it important?
- ▶ What is included in a transition assessment?
- ▶ What are the implications and strategies for individuals with ASD?
- ▶ What are some additional resources related to age appropriate assessment?

### General Information

Transition assessment as defined by the Division on Career Development and Transition (DCDT) of the Council for Exceptional Children as an

"... ongoing process of collecting data on the individual's needs, preferences, and interests as they relate to the demands of current and future working, educational, living, and personal and social environments. Assessment data serve as the common thread in the transition process and form the basis for defining goals and services to be included in the Individualized Education Program (IEP)."

Transition assessment requires planning with meaningful participation from the student and family in order to ensure that the right questions are asked based on the needs and interests of a particular student. Together, the IEP team determines what information is needed to create an effective transition plan for the student.

Once the issues are identified, a set of tools can be selected to collect data to answer these important questions and issues. These tools may be formal or informal tests or a series of job tryouts or situational assessments for independent living. The entire team (including family and student) may then use the results to make decisions and develop a student's course of study, measurable postsecondary goals and transition services.





Char and the IEP team recognize that she enjoys animals. Animals are one of the very few activities in which Char seems interested, engaged and motivated. This is evidenced by a previous portfolio of work, interests and family interviews collected throughout her educational career. At age 14, Char's IEP team developed a plan that would provide her with multiple opportunities in volunteer and potential work sites that involve animals. These opportunities allowed the team to assess Char's strengths and needs, including adaptations to the environment and communication supports. Assessments also focused on Char's ability to demonstrate specific employment skills that have high evidence of successful employment (such as communication and hygiene skills). Basic academic skills were assessed in the functional setting, as well as in a formal testing situation. Finally, functional living skills were assessed via observation in multiple environments using multiple observers.

Based on this combination of formal and informal assessments, the transition plan was developed; however, ongoing assessment was necessary to determine if the identified interventions were successfully allowing Char to develop targeted skills and to assure that she continued to show motivation and interest in working with the targeted pet-sitting business.



# Implications Related to Age-Appropriate Assessment for Individuals with ASD

## Characteristics of ASD – Sensory Processing Challenges

### Implications

Students with an ASD often have sensitivities to sensory input resulting in responses that are difficult to understand. This can intensify during the assessment process. The assessment team should consider the following:

Will the student's sensitivity to the following adversely affect or interfere with the results of the assessment process:

- ▶ Noise or specific sounds?
- ▶ Bright or dim lighting?
- ▶ Smells/Odors?
- ▶ Visual clutter?
- ▶ Lack of personal space?

### Strategies

If there is an adverse effect due to sensory stimulation, possible strategies include:

- ▶ Headphones that muffle sound or provide music
- ▶ Sunglasses, indirect lighting, low lighting, natural lighting or elimination of natural lighting (i.e., away from windows)
- ▶ Removal or reduction of foods, perfumes, air fresheners, printing inks, markers/pens with strong odors, etc.
- ▶ Organized workspace. Remove visual distractions
- ▶ Adequate personal space. This may require physical boundaries (dividers/walls) or simply a designated area

How are sensory issues handled at home or school? Can these strategies be used or adjusted for assessment?

Sensory processing challenges and sensitivities often intensify in stressful situations, unfamiliar routines and with unfamiliar people. Create predictability by using visual strategies, such as pictures, video, social scripts, and clear explanations of what to expect during an assessment process.

Allow the individual multiple opportunities to demonstrate ability and aptitude. A single assessment opportunity is often misleading and does not offer a complete understanding of the student's talents. Increasing the familiarity of the location and individuals involved with the assessment may reduce the stress (and the intensity of the sensory responses) that may develop during the unfamiliar situations of the assessment situation.



# Implications Related to Age-Appropriate Assessment for Individuals with ASD

## Characteristics of ASD – Social/Communication Challenges

### Implications

Individuals with ASD typically struggle to respond to and understand the social aspects of a situation. Social skill training and instruction may be a critical element for an individual with ASD in obtaining or maintaining a job, successfully engaging in and completing postsecondary education and developing satisfying leisure activities. Needed competencies may range from the very basic social skills expected of a young adult to the complex aspects of reading social cues and accurately interpreting another's perspective or point of view.

Social deficits may not only interfere with the assessment process, but must also be considered when identifying the range and types of age-appropriate assessments that are necessary. Questions to consider include:

- ▶ Will the student's social skills and social understanding be a significant barrier to assessment process or to successful postsecondary outcomes?
- ▶ Does the student understand and is the student able to follow verbal directions?
- ▶ Does the student need directions in alternate or multiple formats – verbal, visual or demonstrations?

### Strategies

Do not assume that because a student has received instruction/direction, is able to repeat instructions or is verbal that he understands the intent of the language. Confirm understanding by asking the student to explain what he is to do, demonstrate/model for the student, or provide a trial prior to the assessment.

Use strategies such as direct instruction, social scripts, Power Cards, videos, checklists, priming, visual reminders, role models and rehearsal to ensure that the student understands what to expect and what is expected during the assessment process. (Refer to the OCALI website and/or lending library for information about these specific strategies.)

Provide the student with an effective way to ask for help, request clarification or signal that the situation is too stressful.

Consider the use of informal/observational assessment when evaluating the social, social communication and social emotional competencies of an individual.

Studies indicate that individuals with ASD have great difficulty generalizing social instruction that occurs in a classroom or therapeutic environment to the situation where the skills are to be used (the workplace, cafeteria, community, home, etc.). The most effective practices include instruction and/or reinforcement in the actual environments or situations where the skills must be used. Therefore, recommendations resulting from assessments should consider not only the need for social skills instruction, but also the methods and environments that will be used.

# Implications Related to Age-Appropriate Assessment for Individuals with ASD

## Characteristics of ASD – Executive Function/Organization

### Implications

Individuals with ASD may have great difficulty with organization, attention and mental planning. This challenge may affect the results of the assessment process as the student may have knowledge or skill but not be able to demonstrate these abilities due to difficulty initiating, maintaining focus or solving problems. Organizational and environmental strategies may be necessary during assessment, as well as in daily living and learning situations in order for the person to demonstrate and function at her full potential. Assessment teams should ask:

1. Can the student initiate tasks independently?
2. Does she know how to start and end a task? Does she work systematically?
3. Is the environment conducive to attention and concentration?
4. Does the student require additional environmental assistance in order to independently complete tasks and activities?
5. If the answer to any of these questions is “yes,” how does the assessment need to be structured to accurately assess the student’s skills/abilities?
6. If the answer is “yes” to any of these questions, what are the implications for a job, career or postsecondary education setting?

► Executive Function/Organization  
Strategies con’t. p. 22



# Implications Related to Age-Appropriate Assessment for Individuals with ASD

## Characteristics of ASD – Executive Function/Organization (con't.)

### Strategies

1. Consider organizational supports such as checklists, visual schedules, templates, outlines, visual examples, written directions, timers, labeled bins or shelves, etc. These supports should assist the person in understanding:
  - i. What work is to be completed
  - ii. Where it is to be completed
  - iii. How much is to be completed
  - iv. Where to begin and end tasks
  - v. The allotted time for completing tasks
  - vi. What to do when one is finished

These types of organizational supports may be especially important to the student with ASD during an assessment process that may be new, short term, and with limited time for the student to internalize the task or activity.

2. Assess the environmental stimulation and the potential for distraction. This may include noise levels as well as visual distractions. (Review “Sensory Processing Challenges”).
3. Review and document the organizational supports that were effective during the assessment process. The assessment team should include these as a necessary portion of the ongoing support plan. If possible, student goals should reflect instruction in how to create these supports rather than depending on others to develop the support.
  - i. Example: A student who needs a checklist to complete several tasks in a workplace may be able to learn to create the checklist and then use the list to ensure that all tasks are complete during the work day.
  - ii. Example: A student who has multiple assignments in college classes can be taught a process to record assignment due dates, as well as create a schedule to work systemically towards the completion of each assignment.

# Implications Related to Age-Appropriate Assessment for Individuals with ASD

## Characteristics of ASD – Ritualistic or Repetitive Behavior

### Implications

Students with ASD may demonstrate a number of ritualistic or repetitive behaviors. These may range from physical routines, to verbal repetition, to topical restrictions. In some situations, these behaviors or interests can interfere with completion of an assessment process.

### Strategies

1. If the ritual (such as ordering all items on a desk) are minor and do not interfere with productivity or continued work, allow the student to continue with the behavior and document the intensity of the behavior. Note how the behavior may change as the student becomes more comfortable with the situation.
2. If possible, include the routine behavior as part of the assessment process. For example, if the student needs to discuss a favorite topic prior to beginning the assessment, place “Talk Time” as the first activity instead of struggling to avoid the situation.
3. Document ritualistic behaviors in the assessment process so that these behaviors can be accommodated as part of the job or career. For example, an individual who needs to pace frequently might fit well in a job that requires delivering mail or packages throughout a company. Or an individual who reads manuals and guides could utilize this “obsession” as a proofreader.
4. As part of the assessment, determine what, if any, triggers cause or escalate the ritualistic or repetitive behaviors. Can these be analyzed and minimized by providing environmental or visual supports (such as Adaptive Behavior Cards)? (Refer to the OCALI website and/or lending library for information about these specific strategies.

# Implications Related to Age-Appropriate Assessment for Individuals with ASD

## Characteristics of ASD – Other

### Implications

ASD is complex and varies greatly among individuals on the spectrum. Therefore, even the most thorough transition assessment may not yield all the information that would be important. Sources such as historical data about successful strategies and supports developed for the student by the family and school may be forgotten or not transferred to new settings. Assessment activities can include a review of this information.

Assessment data must also reflect not only plans for the student while in class or working, but also assess the skills, abilities and corresponding supports that will be necessary when not in school or on the job.

- ▶ What will occur if the individual with ASD is only employed part time or attends college part time?
- ▶ Will there be a safe, supervised setting for the individual?
- ▶ Will the student have the necessary skills to prepare and travel to school or work?
- ▶ Will he know how to fill his/her leisure or “down-time” productively?
- ▶ Will he know how to create nutritional meals?

These and other questions should be included as part of the age-appropriate assessment process.

### Strategies

1. Document successful strategies, review with new staff and adjust in new settings.
2. As appropriate, include independent living assessment as an important part of assessment and a successful transition. Assessments related to adaptive behavior or independent living are NOT reserved for students who seem less capable. High-functioning students with ASD or Asperger Syndrome may require extensive assessment. Teams should begin to assess these areas early (age 14) in the transition assessment process. The assessment process should not only identify the need for instruction and skill development in these “functional” areas, but should also provide suggestions for how these skills may be developed while a student is engaging in an academic curriculum. This process is very individualized and should begin as early as possible in order to prevent the crisis that may occur when a student is 17 or 18 and does not have the independent living skills necessary to move into an educational, work, or community living situation.
3. Ensure assessments results reflect potential adult/transitional agency involvement. Early planning for agency eligibility and waiting lists may be necessary.

## Tools and Resources

### **Employability and Life Skills Assessment (ELSA) developed by the Ohio Department of Education.** (See *Appendix C: Employability/Life Skills Assessment*)

This simple-to-use assessment includes a parent and school version to capture information from both home and school environments. A summary chart provides an overview of the identified areas of strength as well as those that can be improved with instruction and activities.

### **Standardized Tests and Students with an Autism Spectrum Disorder**

<http://www.iidc.indiana.edu/irca/generalinfo/standardtests.html>

This article describes the difficulties students with ASD face when taking standardized tests because of social, communication or sensory issues, or ritualistic behaviors. Included is a list of accommodations for taking tests.

### **National Secondary Transition Technical Assistance Center (NSTTAC) Transition Assessment Guide**

<http://www.nsttac.org/Default.aspx?FileName=tag>

Describes how to conduct and select instruments for a transition assessment. Gives examples of sample instruments for both informal and formal assessments and includes links to pod casts and articles on transition assessment.

### **DCDT Age-Appropriate Transition Assessment Fact Sheet**

[http://www.nsttac.org/?FileName=dcdt\\_factsheet](http://www.nsttac.org/?FileName=dcdt_factsheet)

This fact sheet describes how students can be involved in their IEP and the evidence based research supporting this involvement. The 11 steps in the Self Directed IEP process are explained.

### **Questions for Transition Assessment from the Transition Coalition**

<http://www.transitioncoalition.org/cgiwrap/tcacs/new/resources/presentations/index.php>

Sample questions for transition planning and assessment in areas such as employment, post secondary education, community activities and personal/social

are listed along with methods for collecting information in each of these areas.

The Transition Coalition also offers a free online training module on Transition Assessment at <http://www.transitioncoalition.org>.

### **Career Planning Begins with Assessment from the National Collaborative on Work Force and Disability**

[http://www.ncwd-youth.info/resources\\_&\\_Publications/assessment.html](http://www.ncwd-youth.info/resources_&_Publications/assessment.html)

This extensive guide includes chapters on understanding assessment and selecting and using assessments.

### **A Guide for Transition to Adulthood from the Organization for Autism Research**

<http://www.researchautism.org/resources/reading/index.asp>

This free guide includes a section on transition assessment (pp. 9-14) and a form in Appendix D for summarizing interests and skills.

## Agency Collaboration and Funding Related to Assessment

Agencies such as Rehabilitation Services Commission (RSC) and Mental Retardation and Developmental Disabilities (MR/DD) may be invited to meetings where transition assessments are discussed, especially if the student is likely to be served by these agencies in the future. Mental health agencies may also be helpful during the assessment process for students who have a co-occurring mental health challenge.

Agency or adult providers may be able to offer guidance and advice based on assessment results. Many of these agency personnel may not be able to “officially” open a case or follow the student early in the transition process; however, the assessment process is a natural time to introduce the student, family and other team members to potential adult service providers. The assessment planning process should include a discussion of the multiple types of agencies that are available and which agencies should be approached to officially or unofficially participate.



Tyrone and his team decided that it was in his best interest to delay his graduation until his 22nd birthday. Tyrone is a talented, yet complex young man who has been identified with high-functioning autism and bipolar disorder. At age 17, with Tyrone and his family's permission, the IEP team invited MR/DD, BVR, the local mental health agency and an adult advocacy organization to attend a "getting to know Tyrone" meeting. At this meeting the agency representatives were given information about Tyrone, his strengths, his vision for the future and his potential needs. The agency representatives offered advice related to additional assessments, applications, resources and general information related to their experience. Several months later an official IEP/transition planning meeting was held, and the same people were invited to attend. Tyrone's parents signed releases so that minutes from the IEP meetings and the Transition Plans were made available to the agencies.

school building. These activities and resulting skills are documented and included as part of the historical data.

A transition assessment program structure should support family involvement, a student-centered approach and ongoing individualized assessment with early transition planning, especially in critical areas such as residential living. The program structure should include staff knowledgeable about community resources and contacts for interagency collaboration and a creative use of resources.



Agencies such as RSC may be able to assist in funding for certain assessments. MR/DD may provide certain assessments, such as assessment of travel or mobility. For students who qualify for Medicaid, this may be another resource for assessments related to medical needs.

## Activities or Interventions to Facilitate Planning, Implementation and Use of Assessment Tools and Procedures

Early opportunities for self-determination activities, such as choice making, goal setting and decision-making, will provide a foundation for a student's active participation in transition assessment. Therefore, they should be included as part of student's educational program as soon as possible.

Ongoing career development activities at school and home, such as job shadowing, community experiences and volunteering, will contribute to a more meaningful transition assessment. These may begin early in a student's educational career within the classroom or

Antonio's family requested that a visioning process be used to help plan his future. The people who knew Antonio best participated in this process. These included his teacher, parents, brothers, sister, aunt, uncles, therapists, several friends from school and a long-time family friend. The process centered on Antonio as a unique individual. This process guided the development of the transition Vision Statement and the goals for Antonio's adult life.

## Summary

### Age-Appropriate Assessment

"Age appropriate" means chronological age rather than developmental age (Wehmeyer, 2002).

### IDEA Requirements

Age-appropriate transition assessments are required by the law IDEA 2004.

### Focus

Assessment areas include education/training, employment and, when necessary, independent living.

### Student and Family Participation

Student participation in transition planning ensures that students' interests and preferences are reflected in the results. Families can also contribute important information concerning student medical history and continuity regarding background information that may be otherwise forgotten by school or agency personnel.

### Data Driven

Transition assessment data drive the transition planning and the development of IEP goals. Accurate and meaningful transition assessment data support the development and achievement of appropriate and measurable postsecondary goals for employment, postsecondary education and independent living.

### Not a Single Test

There is no one "correct" transition assessment format or set of tests. Transition assessments are individualized and collect data on a particular student's needs, aptitudes, interests and abilities.

### Multiple Assessments

Transition assessments can include formal testing (achievement, aptitude, and interest), informal testing (interviews, observations, questionnaires) and situational work assessments. Behavioral, self determination and independent living assessments should be considered and may be included when determined to be necessary for future planning.

### Ongoing

Transition assessments do not take place at one point in time. They are ongoing throughout the high school years and should reflect data from more than one person.

### Meaningful Summary of Results

A report that summarizes results and an explanation of the results should be given to the family and team members. Transition assessment results should assist the student and family in participating in the transition process and making informed decisions about life choices.

### Documentation

The assessment results should also be reflected in the Present Levels of Performance of the IEP and the Summary of Performance, a document given to the student upon exiting the school system.